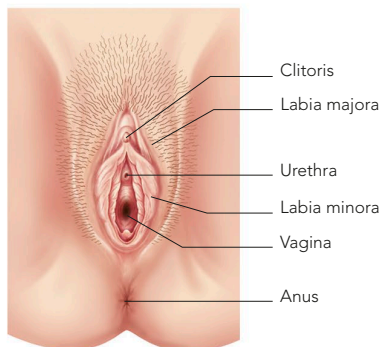


VULVA

The external genital parts of the female are together known as the vulva. They are sited under the mons pubis, a mound of fatty tissue that covers the junction of the two pubic bones, the pubic symphysis. On the outside are the flap-like labia majora, and the smaller, fold-like labia minora lie within them. The labia majora contain sebaceous glands, smooth muscle, and sensory nerve endings. At puberty, their exposed surfaces begin to grow hairs. Within the vulva are the openings to the vagina and the urethra. At the front end of the labia minora is the clitoris. Like the male penis, it is sensitive and engorges with blood when aroused.



EXTERNAL GENITALS

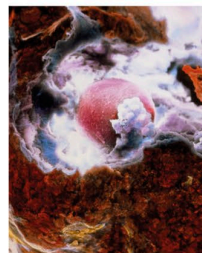
The external genitals have a protective role, preventing infection from reaching the urethra or vagina, but allowing urine to exit.

OVULATION

An ovary contains thousands of immature egg cells. During a menstrual cycle, follicle-stimulating hormone (FSH) causes one egg to develop inside a primary follicle. As the follicle enlarges, it moves to the ovary's surface and produces more oestrogen. At ovulation, a surge of luteinizing hormone (LH) causes this secondary follicle to rupture and release the ripe egg. The lining of the empty follicle thickens into a corpus luteum – a temporary source of hormones.

EGG RELEASE

This coloured electron micrograph shows an egg (red) as it is being released from its follicle into the abdominal cavity. Tendrils (fimbriae) at the end of each fallopian tube guide the egg into the tube.



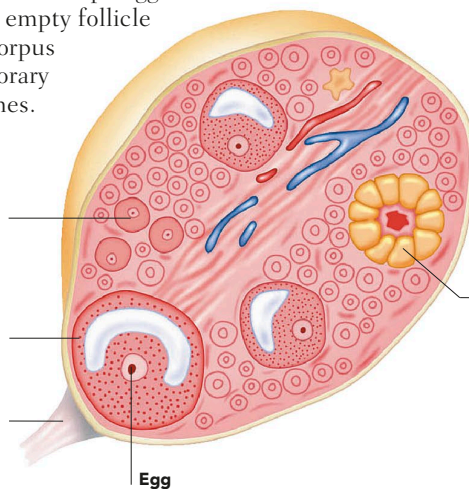
INSIDE AN OVARY

The ovary contains eggs that are undeveloped, eggs inside follicles at various stages of maturation, and empty follicles forming corpora lutea. The glandular tissue around these follicles is known as the stroma.

Primary follicle
Early development; contains primary oocyte (unripe egg cell)

Secondary follicle
Mature stage of development, containing secondary oocyte (ripened egg)

Ovarian ligament
Stabilizes position of ovary within abdomen



Corpus luteum
An empty follicle, filled with hormone-producing cells